

NEWS SPORTS LINEUP



Cohen Wants Team Like 1927 Bisons

By Evening News Baseball Writer

Cy Kritzer

Tropical skies streaked jagged lightning and massive black clouds moved swiftly here over Municipal Field, at the Bison baseball training base in Pompano Beach, Fla. In ten minutes the baseball diamond was inches deep in water. Buffalo and Indianapolis squads sulked in the clubhouse.

Andy Cohen, the Indians' manager, was in a reminiscent mood. He was thinking back 30 years when he wore the Buffalo uniform and went on to have his greatest year at shortstop for the 1927 International League pennant-winning Bisons. Andy batted .345, drove in 118 runs and hit 14 homers and 36 doubles.



ANDY COHEN

"I'd like to manage a ball club like that 1927 Buffalo team," said Andy. "There was Del Bissonette at first base and he drove in about 170 runs; Lew Malone, second base; Bill Huber, third base, and Eddie Taylor, the utility man. Mickey Devine and Art Pond were the catchers. In the outfield were Al Tyson, Fred Brainard and Andy Anderson. We had steady pitching from Curley Ogden, Leo Mangum, Eurie Profitt, Red Brice, Walter Leverenz and Jim Wiltse.

"The players are just as good today; just as fast and maybe stronger physically. But they aren't as hungry and as ambitious as the players in the 1927 era. They collect a bonus for signing and it does something to their incentive.

"There are so many other fine opportunities today for a young fellow; if he doesn't make good in baseball he can find a high-paying job in another field."

The key man of the Bisons' outfield is 27-year-old Rodney Graber, a left-hand thrower and batter whose batting style probably will be copied by youngsters in The News Midget Leagues and American Legion Junior baseball.

Graber is a stylist who has made an art of hitting the ball where it is pitched. He has worked pitchers for an average of more than 100 walks a season.

A graceful runner, Graber was a hurdler and sprinter at Dalton High School in Ohio. He starred in football as a halfback and signed his first baseball contract in 1950 after graduating from high school.

Despite his slick fielding and class as a runner and batter, Graber made slow progress in the Cleveland Indians' farm system. His big thrill came in his first year, when he received a set of luggage as the most popular player on the Green Bay club in the Wisconsin State League.

On Graber Night, the rookie produced six straight hits—two triples, two doubles and a pair of singles.

"My job," said Graber, "is to get on base. Last year, Kerby Ferrell at Indianapolis had me going for the long ball, and I was overswinging and not meeting the ball squarely. You have to know your limitations in this game. I'm a punch and slash hitter. I'll get some home runs, but I won't be going for the homer when I do."

At 5 feet 10½ inches and 170 pounds, Graber is the smallest Bison regular. At 27 he is starting his seventh season in pro ball. He played winter ball the last two seasons. Meanwhile, he is taking courses in salesmanship.

It didn't take him long to sell Manager Phil Cavarretta that he is on his way to becoming one of the top leadoff batters and center-fielders in the International League.